

THE DRAGON

Draco



SIZE RANKING 8

BRIGHTEST STAR

Eltanin (γ) 2.2

GENITIVE Draconis

ABBREVIATION Dra

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM
April–AugustFULLY VISIBLE
90°N–4°S

One of the ancient Greek constellations, Draco represents the dragon of Greek myth that was slain by Hercules (see panel, below). This large constellation winds for nearly 180° around the north celestial pole. Despite its size, Draco is not particularly easy to identify, apart from a lozenge shape marking the head. This is formed by four stars, including the constellation's brightest member, Gamma (γ) Draconis, popularly known as Eltanin, meaning “the serpent.”

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Double and multiple stars are a particular feature of Draco. Nu (ν) Draconis, the faintest of the four stars in the dragon's head, is a readily identifiable pair. It consists of identical white components of 5th magnitude

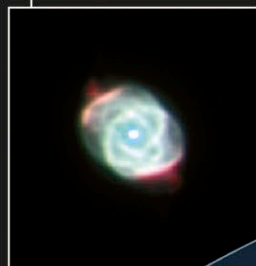
and is considered to be among the finest doubles visible with binoculars. Psi (ψ) Draconis is a somewhat closer pair, with components of 5th and 6th magnitudes, and requires a small telescope to be divided. More challenging to discern is Mu (μ) Draconis, with its two 6th-magnitude stars, which requires a telescope with high magnification to be seen as double.

The wide pair of stars 16 and 17 Draconis is easily spotted with binoculars, and the brighter of the two—17 Draconis—can be further divided with a small telescope with high magnification, turning this into a triple star. A similar triple is 39 Draconis; when viewed with a small telescope with low magnification, it appears a double, but at higher magnification, the brighter star divides into a closer pair with components of magnitudes 5.0 and 8.0. Two more doubles that can readily be seen with a small telescope are Omicron ($\omicron$) Draconis, with stars of 5th and 8th magnitudes, and 40 and 41 Draconis, which are both 6th-magnitude orange dwarfs.

In central Draco lies a planetary nebula made famous by a striking Hubble Space Telescope image: NGC 6543, or the Cat's Eye Nebula (see p.258). Processed in false color, the Hubble picture shows the nebula as red, but when seen through a small telescope it appears blue-green, as do all planetary nebulae.

THE CAT'S EYE NEBULA 𐄂 𐄃

This amateur CCD image of NGC 6543 shows some of the color and structure captured by the Hubble Space Telescope, but visually the nebula appears as a blue-green ellipse.



BEAR AND DRAGON 𐄂 𐄃

The long body of Draco curls around the stars of Ursa Minor, the Little Bear. The head of the dragon is easily identifiable.



MYTHS AND STORIES

HERCULES AND THE DRAGON

The dragon Ladon guarded the golden apples that grew on Mount Atlas in the garden of Hera, wife of Zeus. As his twelfth labor, the hero Hercules was required to steal some apples. To get to them, he killed the dragon with a poisoned arrow. Hera placed the dragon in the sky as the constellation Draco.

DRAGON KILLER

In this 16th-century painting by the Italian artist Lorenzo dello Sciorina, Hercules is depicted slaying the dragon by hand.

